market area of Srinagar. Those who live by the sword shall die by the sword.

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I had two sector commanders, in Brigs DC Katoch (Armoured) and Vicky Mehta (Armoured) and three GsOC, in Maj Gen Nirbhay Sharma (Para), Dalbir Singh (Para) and S Yadav (Raj Rif). All of them supported me to the hilt. I think I was lucky to have my immediate superiors from the Armoured Corps, as they did not interfere in the conduct of operations, trusting my better judgement as an Infantryman. They provided the higher direction and took care of the 'flak' in case of any adverse publicity or fall-out, as had happened at Trigam. Maj Gen Nirbhay Sharma was a hard task-master, who really pushed me hard to produce results, especially on the Samra case. Maj Gen Dalbir Singh was a more hands-on type, even reaching the site of ongoing encounters and joining in the operation, merrily chucking hand grenades into the target houses. Maj Gen S Yadav was a thorough gentleman, soft-spoken, who remained unfazed in any crisis. Of all the GsOC, I had the longest association with Maj Gen Dalbir Singh.

Brig Dalbir Singh had been the Commander of 71 Sub Area, located along with the Corps HQ at Srinagar. Once in the winter of 2001, we were conducting yet another operation in Lawepura village. While driving past that location, he saw this activity and though not in his charter, got down to have a look, asking one of the jawans to take him to the CO. I was somewhere in the middle of the village, wearing my BPJ and helmet, crouched down in the snow behind a stone wall, passing instructions on the radio set, when Brig Dalbir appeared from behind me and crouched down alongside.

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